Warmed By A Campfire

Why I Belong and Believe

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August 2026

Allow me to introduce myself: Professionally, I am a scientist, specializing in how light and atoms—some of the smallest bits of matter and energy—interact. I love this discipline because of its symmetry and beauty, but also its complexity and unexpected outcomes. Personally, I am a husband, father, son, brother, grandson, uncle, and friend. Each of these relationships and roles brings me great meaning and satisfaction. I am also a believer in God and a member of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. In some minds, a religious scientist may be an oxymoron. But I disagree. In science, fundamental principles can help explain or predict "larger" physical phenomena. Similarly, my faith is a fundamental attribute of my character, roles, and relationships. I find that my religious tradition and faith deeply inform, enrich and explain both professional and personal aspects of my life, and vice versa. In this document, I attempt to articulate *why* I belong to the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, where this faith in God came from, and why I maintain it.

My first reflection is on the rich network I have as a member of the Church. Wherever I find myself, I frequently feel a sense of belonging with Latter-day Saints. One Sunday morning on a solo road trip, I stopped in a small, remote town to attend a church meeting. As I closed the driver's door, I realized in panic that my keys remained locked inside. With no other immediate options, I entered the building in my dirty, wrinkled travel clothes where an older gentleman introduced himself. Learning of my plight, he talked with other friends in the congregation until he found someone with a Slim Jim at home. After retrieving the tool, this man and two others assisted me in opening the locked door of my car. The relief of being able to continue my journey was palpable. I wish I knew their names! They dropped everything to help a "stranger."

It goes beyond spontaneous acts of goodness. In this Church, I see organized and coordinated efforts to care for each other, both neighbors down the street and neighbors around the world. A few years ago, during a particularly stressful move for my family, more than 30 friends from my congregation arrived at my home to load a moving truck and unload it at the new house, some staying after to assemble furniture. Although a huge help for us, this was not an isolated or special case. I have assisted many moves, and such efforts are repeated every Saturday in LDS congregations across the country. Congregations work together. On volunteer assignments to clean church buildings, I have also seen a prominent local church leader quietly wielding a toilet scrubber or pushing a vacuum. We have a lay-clergy, but basically a lay-everything: non-professional volunteers fill all roles in Church function, each contributing his or her best. This means that I constantly interact with people from all sorts of personal and socioeconomic backgrounds. In a given week, I learn from the experiences of medical doctors, octogenarians, military veterans, engineers, stay-at-home mothers, trade workers, immigrants, teenagers, or cancer patients. The global presence of the Church also invites me to take an open, universal perspective on humankind. All of this provides a deep richness of diversity and experience, coalescing around our love for Jesus Christ.

The Church also empowers me to learn, question, reason and gain as much education as possible, from high school to doctoral schooling. I am inspired by the Church's implementing affordable, certified higher education programs for individuals throughout the world. A friend—a graduate of one of these programs—once commented on how good it feels to finally have a good job that can support his wife and children.

Being part of this Church community and striving to follow the teachings of Jesus Christ has changed my character and disposition for the better. This Church is rightly known as a family-centered

Church, and following its guidance has made me a better husband, father, son, and brother. Compared to how I was as a teenager and young adult, I am happier and more patient than ever. I am better able to understand and give space for the different experiences of others and see the good from many different sources. Importantly, the Church's teaching has expanded my ability to forgive my own shortcomings and failings, bringing me greater peace and confidence.

All these experiences are rooted in central, foundational beliefs that I hold, which are—in a nutshell: That God exists and that every human being on earth is a son or daughter of Him; God demonstrates His love for every person by sending His Son, Jesus Christ, to save and redeem all who come to Jesus[1]; The immense love of God demands of me that I see and treat others with dignity, respect, and love; I consider the restored Church as the commissioned and authorized organization that Jesus ordained to gather God's children home to Him in love[2]; Although I constantly fall short of God's high expectations for me[3], I glory in the forgiveness and strengthening grace that God offers me[4].

So, where do these beliefs come from—for me? I was blessed to be born and raised in a good family with religious and dedicated parents who taught me about God and actively demonstrated their faith. They were certainly instrumental in my starting out along this path. However, I do not believe that their influence could have sustained my faith across distance and time until now.

The true origin of my personal belief in God might be compared to a campfire. If, on an extended hike through an uninhabited and untamed region of Alaska, I were to stumble upon an unattended—but blazing—bonfire, I would reasonably conclude that someone had been there before me—and was likely nearby. Similarly, my beliefs about God arose from unexpected personal encounters along this trail of life. These are a few such "campfires":

At seven years old, when asked directly, I could only guess what the Spirit of God felt like. However, immediately after my baptism at age eight, I distinctly felt something *good*—something of genuine warmth and love—infuse into my soul. It was unprompted; I could not have said where it came from[5]. This was the first time I can confidently say I felt the Holy Spirit. A few years later, my father taught me one day from the scriptures, telling me that God knew me and of my potential. I was stunned by this simple declaration. As I pondered this thought alone, I felt something completely fill me with intense energy and love. I felt God. I sensed unquestionably that God exists, that I have a soul, and that He knows me and loves me perfectly as one of His children. I attribute the fact that I am still alive today to the knowledge gained in that moment. Later, as a full-time missionary, I shared the story of the modern restoration of the Church of Jesus Christ hundreds of times, but an experience stands out during a visit with a couple and their 9 year-old son. As my companion and I described Joseph Smith's First Vision experience, this young boy—who had little prior understanding of God—began to softly weep. He felt what we all felt—as if the entire room were vibrating with power and energy: the Spirit of God filled that place. We felt God.

To encounter one campfire on a remote path is startling; to find it repeatedly is a suspicious pattern. The combination of these (and many other) sacred experiences compounds strong evidence for my belief in God and His reaching out to me. To be a man of integrity and honesty, the cumulative evidence compels me to continue along this path of faith and religion, no matter how hard it may become. This is not to say that I completely understand why or how these events occurred. Even before mankind knew the physics and chemistry of combustion, they could still sit around a campfire and warm their hands: that is, despite lacking a clear, rigorous explanation, the fire could still be *felt*. Similarly, God's power has warmed my soul during the chilly nights of loneliness, fear, and despair.

For the person who gives my eulogy after I die, I hope they begin with the words "Benjamin was a believer." For me, these four words encapsulate my attitude toward faith, religion, family, science, and life itself. They dictate how and why I belong in the restored Church and why I choose to continue walking this path. The pattern is clear: I expect many more campfires ahead.



1. Romans 5:8; 3 Nephi 27:13-20
2. For more information, see `www.comeuntochrist.org/`.
3. Romans 3:23
4. Ephesians 1:6-8; 2 Nephi 33:6; Mosiah 4:2-3
5. John 3:8